

Zara and the Golden Rule

A story about empathy, treating others the way you want to be treated

Written by Daniel Tesfamariam

For children ages 4-10

[Illustration: Beautiful, colorful cover art depicting the main character]

Dedication

To every child learning empathy the world becomes a better place one kind action at a time. You have the power to change everything.

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Zara was eight years old, and she thought she was pretty great. She was funny, smart, and the fastest runner in her class.

The problem was, Zara wasn't always nice about it.

She laughed when others tripped. She bragged when she won races. She told her classmates their ideas were dumb.

Zara didn't think she was being mean. She thought she was just being honest. But the other kids didn't feel that way.

[Illustration: A confident young girl with curly hair, arms crossed with a smirk, on a school playground, other children looking hurt or annoyed in the background]

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'Zara, why can't you be nicer?' her mother asked one evening after a phone call from school.

'I AM nice!' Zara protested. 'I just say what I think! Everyone's too sensitive!'

'How would you feel if someone laughed at YOUR mistakes?' her mother asked gently.

Zara rolled her eyes. 'That's different. I don't make mistakes.'

Her mother sighed and kissed her forehead. 'One day, sweetheart, you'll understand.'

[Illustration: Zara and her mother at the kitchen table, mother looking concerned, Zara looking dismissive and unbothered, a gentle confrontation]

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The very next day, something strange happened.

Zara found a small golden mirror in her desk at school. It wasn't there before. No one saw who left it.

It was beautiful oval-shaped with a golden frame carved with the words: 'SEE WHAT THEY SEE. FEEL WHAT THEY FEEL.'

When Zara looked into it, she didn't see her own reflection. She saw... someone else. Someone familiar.

It was showing her classmate, Malik, and he looked upset.

[Illustration: Zara finding a mysterious golden oval mirror in her school desk, the frame inscribed with golden words, looking into it and seeing not her own face but another child's face looking sad]

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As Zara watched the mirror, she felt a rush of emotion that wasn't hers. Embarrassment. Shame. A sinking feeling in the stomach. The burning of tears being held back.

She FELT what Malik was feeling. And then she saw why in the mirror, she watched herself from yesterday, laughing at Malik when he stuttered during his class presentation.

'Ha! Can't even talk right!' Mirror-Zara had said. And Mirror-Malik's heart had crumpled like paper.

Zara dropped the mirror in shock. 'That's... that's how he felt when I laughed?'

[Illustration: Zara looking into the mirror in shock, seeing a scene of herself laughing at Malik, with visible emotion waves coming from the mirror into her heart, feeling his pain for the first time]

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At recess, Zara raced to the swings she always got there first because she was fastest.

She pushed ahead of a smaller girl named Deepa. 'I'm first! Move!'

Deepa stepped back, eyes down. Zara barely noticed. She was already swinging.

But then she glanced at the mirror in her pocket. It was glowing softly.

She peeked at it and felt Deepa's feelings hit her like a wave: small, invisible, not important enough.

[Illustration: Zara on the swing, the golden mirror glowing in her pocket, a small girl walking away looking dejected, Zara's face changing from smug to troubled as she peeks at the mirror]

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All day, the mirror showed Zara how her words and actions made others feel.

When she told Leo his drawing was ugly: hurt. Pride crushed. The desire to never draw again.

When she ignored Nina trying to tell a story: invisible. Unimportant. Like her words didn't matter.

When she rolled her eyes at the teacher's joke: dismissed. Embarrassed in front of the whole class.

By the end of the day, Zara had felt more sadness than she'd ever felt in her whole life. And it was all sadness SHE had caused.

[Illustration: A montage of Zara throughout the day making faces, saying mean things with the mirror showing her the feelings she caused: crushed expressions, hurt hearts, invisible people]

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That night, Zara cried in bed. Not because anyone was mean to HER, but because she finally understood how mean SHE had been.

'I didn't know,' she whispered to the mirror. 'I didn't know they felt like that.'

The mirror glowed gently, and new words appeared on its frame: 'NOW YOU KNOW. WHAT WILL YOU DO?'

Zara wiped her tears. She thought about how she'd want to be treated if she were Malik. Or Deepa. Or Leo. Or Nina.

She'd want kindness. She'd want to feel seen. She'd want people to build her up, not tear her down.

[Illustration: Zara in bed at night, crying, holding the golden mirror, new golden words appearing on its frame, Zara looking determined through her tears to change]

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The next morning, Zara made a decision. She would treat everyone the way she'd want to be treated.

At school, when Malik raised his hand to answer a question and stuttered on a word, Zara didn't laugh.

Instead, she waited patiently, and when he got his answer right, she said, 'Good answer, Malik!'

She peeked at the mirror. Malik's feeling: surprised. Happy. Proud. Like sunshine after a storm.

Zara smiled. Making someone feel GOOD felt way better than making them feel bad.

[Illustration: Zara in class giving Malik a thumbs up after his answer, Malik looking surprised and happy, the mirror in Zara's pocket glowing with warm golden light, a positive moment]

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At recess, Zara arrived at the swings first as usual. Deepa was walking toward them slowly, expecting to be pushed aside.

Instead, Zara stepped back. 'Want to go first today, Deepa?'

Deepa's mouth fell open. 'Really?'

'Really,' Zara smiled.

The mirror showed Deepa's feeling: shocked. Valued. Important. Like she mattered.

And Zara? Waiting for the swing didn't hurt at all. But Deepa's smile was worth a thousand turns.

[Illustration: Zara stepping aside and gesturing for Deepa to take the swing first, Deepa's face lighting up with surprise and joy, other kids watching this unusual act of kindness]

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Day after day, Zara practiced the Golden Rule: treat others the way you want to be treated.

She complimented Leo's drawing (his feeling: inspired, confident). She listened to Nina's whole story (feeling: heard, valued).

She cheered for classmates who did well (feeling: supported, celebrated).

She apologized to people she'd hurt before (feeling: healed, forgiven, relieved).

Each act of kindness felt like planting a seed. And those seeds were growing fast.

[Illustration: Zara being kind in multiple scenes – complimenting art, listening attentively, cheering for others – each person glowing with positive emotions, the mirror showing happy faces]

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Something incredible started happening. The kindness was spreading. Malik, who Zara had encouraged, started encouraging the shy kids in class. Deepa, who Zara had let go first, started sharing her snacks with others. Leo, whose art Zara had praised, started drawing pictures for lonely classmates to cheer them up. Zara's kindness had started a ripple that spread through the entire school.

[Illustration: A ripple effect visualization Zara's kindness spreading to Malik, then to others, then to even more people, like dominoes of good feelings cascading through the school]

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One afternoon, something happened that Zara never expected.

She tripped during a race in gym class and fell flat on her face. The old Zara's biggest fear looking foolish in front of everyone.

She lay on the ground, cheeks burning with embarrassment, waiting for the laughter.

But instead of laughing... everyone rushed to help her up.

'Are you okay, Zara?' 'Nice try, that was a hard race!' 'You'll get it next time!'

[Illustration: Zara fallen on a gym track, classmates rushing to help her up instead of laughing, hands reaching out to her from every direction, surprised and touched by the kindness]

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Zara looked up at all those kind faces and felt tears prick her eyes happy tears this time.

They were treating her the way she'd been treating them. With kindness. With support. With love.

The Golden Rule worked both ways when you treat others well, they treat YOU well too.

She looked at the mirror one more time. It showed her OWN feelings now: loved. Supported.

Part of something beautiful.

She didn't need the mirror to tell her that. She could feel it in her own heart.

[Illustration: Zara on the ground looking up at smiling classmates with happy tears in her eyes, the mirror showing her own joyful feelings, a moment of beautiful realization]

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That evening, Zara tried to look at the mirror again. But it had changed.

Instead of showing other people's feelings, it simply showed her own reflection a girl with kind eyes and a gentle smile.

The golden words now read: 'You no longer need me. You can feel what others feel on your own now. That's called empathy.'

Zara hugged the mirror to her chest. 'Thank you,' she whispered. 'Thank you for showing me.'

[Illustration: Zara looking into the mirror which now shows her own kind reflection, the golden words about empathy glowing warmly, Zara holding it gratefully]

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The next day, the mirror was gone. Vanished from her desk like it had never been there. But Zara didn't need it anymore. She had learned to do what the mirror did she could imagine how others felt before she acted.

Before saying something, she'd think: 'How would I feel if someone said this to ME?'

Before doing something, she'd think: 'Would I want someone to do this to ME?'

It was that simple. And it changed everything.

[Illustration: Zara at school without the mirror, pausing thoughtfully before speaking, an imaginary thought bubble showing herself in the other person's shoes, practicing empathy naturally]

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By the end of the school year, Zara's class was the kindest, happiest class in the whole school.

They had the fewest arguments, the most laughter, and the strongest friendships.

Their teacher called them 'The Golden Rule Class' and other teachers brought their students to observe.

'What's your secret?' other kids asked.

'It's simple,' Zara would say. 'Before you do anything, ask yourself: would I want someone to do this to me?'

[Illustration: Zara's classroom full of happy, kind children working together and laughing, a banner reading 'The Golden Rule Class,' other students peeking in curiously from the doorway]

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Zara's mother hugged her one evening. 'I'm so proud of who you're becoming,' she said. 'I understand now, Mom,' Zara said. 'When I was mean, I thought I was being strong. But I was actually weak.'

'Being kind when you could be mean THAT'S strength. Thinking about others' feelings before your own THAT'S courage.'

'And the best part? When you treat people well, the whole world treats YOU well back. It's like magic.'

Her mother smiled. 'It IS magic. It's the oldest magic there is. The Golden Rule.'

[Illustration: Zara and her mother hugging at home, both smiling warmly, evening light coming through the window, a scene of growth and pride and love between mother and daughter]

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One day, a new student arrived at school. His name was Omar, and he was shy and quiet. Some kids ignored him. Others whispered about his accent. Omar sat alone at lunch, staring at his food.

Zara watched him and immediately thought: 'How would I feel on my first day at a new school with no friends?'

She knew the answer. Lonely. Scared. Invisible. She walked straight over to his table.

'Hi Omar! I am Zara. Want to sit with us? We have an empty spot and my friend Malik tells the funniest jokes.'

[Illustration: Zara walking confidently over to the new boy Omar who sits alone, reaching out her hand, other kids at her table waving welcomingly, Omar looking surprised and hopeful]

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Omar's face lit up. 'Really? You want me to sit with you?'

'Of course!' Zara smiled. She remembered how Deepa had felt when someone finally noticed her. She remembered what it was like to feel included.

By the end of lunch, Omar was laughing at Malik's jokes, sharing stories about his old country, and looking like he belonged.

'Thank you, Zara,' Omar said quietly as the bell rang. 'I was so scared nobody would talk to me.'

'I know that feeling,' Zara said. 'And I never want anyone to feel it if I can help.'

[Illustration: Omar laughing at the lunch table with Zara and her friends, completely included and happy, a transformation from lonely to belonging in one lunch period]

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Zara also learned that the Golden Rule wasn't just about big moments it was about tiny ones too.

Holding the door for someone carrying heavy things. Saying 'good morning' to the janitor.

Picking up a dropped pencil.

Smiling at someone who looks sad. Saying 'please' and 'thank you' like you mean it.

These tiny acts didn't seem like much, but the mirror had shown her even small kindnesses create big feelings in others.

Every single interaction was a chance to make the world a tiny bit better.

[Illustration: A montage of Zara doing small kind acts throughout her day holding doors, greeting the janitor, picking up dropped items, smiling at people each one creating a small golden glow]

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Sometimes, Zara messed up. She was still human, after all.

Sometimes she said something without thinking and saw the hurt flash across someone's face.

But the difference now was that she NOTICED. She felt it. And she fixed it immediately.

'I am sorry. That came out wrong. What I meant to say was...' became one of her most-used phrases.

And people always forgave her because they knew she genuinely cared about their feelings.

[Illustration: Zara catching herself after saying something thoughtless, immediately apologizing with sincerity, the other person's expression softening from hurt to understanding]

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So here's what Zara learned and what she wants YOU to know:

You have more power than you think. Every word you say and every thing you do affects the people around you.

You can make someone's day wonderful or terrible with just one sentence, one action, one choice.

So before you speak, before you act, ask yourself the Golden Rule question:

'Would I want someone to treat ME this way?'

If the answer is yes go ahead. If the answer is no choose differently. It really is that simple.

[Illustration: A child looking directly at the reader with kind eyes and an open expression, a golden glow around them representing the power they have to affect others positively, empowering and warm]

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Here is your Golden Rule challenge:

Tomorrow, before every single thing you say or do, pause for ONE second and ask: Would I want this done to me?

Before you tease someone pause. Before you ignore someone pause. Before you grab something first pause.

Just one second of thinking can change everything. One second turns a hurtful moment into a kind one.

Try it for one day. Then try it for a week. Then watch your whole world transform, just like Zara's did.

[Illustration: A child pausing before speaking, a small golden clock showing one second, the moment of choice between kindness and unkindness, choosing the golden path]

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And remember: the Golden Rule is not just about being nice. It is about SEEING people. Seeing when someone is lonely. Seeing when someone is hurt. Seeing when someone needs a friend.

You do not need a magic mirror to do this. You just need to pay attention.

Look at the people around you really look. What do they need? What would YOU need in their shoes?

The answer to that question is always the right thing to do. Always.

[Illustration: A child looking around their classroom or playground, truly SEEING the people around them noticing who is lonely, who is hurt, who needs a friend with a gentle golden glow of awareness around them]

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The Golden Rule is the oldest rule in the world. Every culture, every religion, every wise teacher has taught it.

Treat others as you want to be treated. It is that simple. And it is that powerful.

One person using this rule can change a classroom. A classroom can change a school. A school can change a town.

And you? You are that one person. Start today. Start now.

The mirror is in your heart. The gold is in your hands. The rule is yours to live.

[Illustration: A golden rule emblem glowing in a child's heart, ripples of golden light spreading outward to their classroom, their school, their community, showing how one person changes everything]

The Moral of the Story

Treat Others as You Want to Be Treated

Zara discovered that every action has a ripple. When she was mean, everyone around her became mean. When she was kind, everyone became kind. The Golden Rule is the most powerful rule in the world: treat others the way YOU want to be treated. Before you speak, imagine those words being said to you. Before you act, imagine someone doing that to you. If it would hurt you, don't do it to others. If it would make you happy, go ahead and spread that joy! You have the power to change your whole world one kind action at a time.

Discussion Questions for Parents

After reading this story together, talk about these questions:

1. If you had Zara's mirror, what do you think it would show you about how your words make others feel?
2. Can you think of a time when someone's words hurt you? How did it feel? How would you want them to have treated you instead?
3. What does 'treat others as you want to be treated' mean in YOUR life? Give a specific example.
4. Why do you think Zara's whole class became kinder after she changed? How does one person's behavior affect everyone?
5. What's one thing you could change about how you treat others this week?

About the Author

Daniel Tesfamariam is a storyteller who believes every child deserves stories that spark imagination, build character, and fill hearts with wonder.

His stories are crafted to help children understand important life lessons through adventure, friendship, and the magic of imagination.

When not writing, Daniel enjoys spending time with family, exploring nature, and dreaming up new worlds for young readers to discover.

Thank you for reading! If your child enjoyed this story, please look for other books in the collection.